

Call Global, Pay Local!

Annoyed at spending a fortune on long distance calls? The answer is calling cards, a reasonably-priced option for individuals and SoHos

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Today, any business, big or small, demands some amount of travelling. Keeping in touch with associates and colleagues is also a critical aspect. Organisations around the world are looking at reducing ever-rising communications costs.

As a result, travellers are warming up to the concept of using calling cards to call home from a foreign country. Although the international market is flooded with a plethora of calling cards, the Indian scenario is vastly different and the concept is still in its infancy. Only a handful of players such as BSNL, MTNL, VSNL or Tata Indicom in the public sector and Reliance, Net4India and Bharti Infotel in the private sector offer these services.

Despite the lack of services being offered, though, the outlook for the future is a positive one. With 6.8 crore telephone lines, India boasts an annual growth rate of 22 per cent in basic telephony and over 100 per cent for cellular and Internet services. Tele-density has risen to eight per cent already.

The Players

Although young, telecom companies in India have realised that

this is a segment that cannot be ignored and are trying their best to beat each other in the race. Here's a look at the different options available.

VSNL: Since the takeover by Tata Teleservices, there have been a lot of innovations at VSNL. The Tata Indicom range includes the 'Tata Indicom Calling Cards', 'Global Calling Cards', 'Hello Duniya' calling cards and 'India-On-Call' calling cards.

BSNL: BSNL's prepaid card is called the 'India Telephone' card which can be used to make STD, ISD and even local calls.

MTNL: MTNL is currently offering the 'Virtual Calling Card' in its markets and is aimed at the traveller. It allows users to make a

call from any tone-dialling telephone locally, nationally and internationally.

Reliance: Reliance Infocomm has launched the 'World Card', a prepaid international calling card. The 'World Card' is a prepaid, rechargeable account-based service that can be used from any Reliance phone—RIM (post- and pre-paid) and Reliance IndiaPhone (Fixed Wireless Phones and Terminals).

Bharti Infotel: IndiaOne, the long distance service provider from Bharti Infotel offers the 'Home Touch International' calling card. This card can be used in more than 35 major countries including the US, Europe, Southeast Asia, Asia-Pacific and the Far East.

